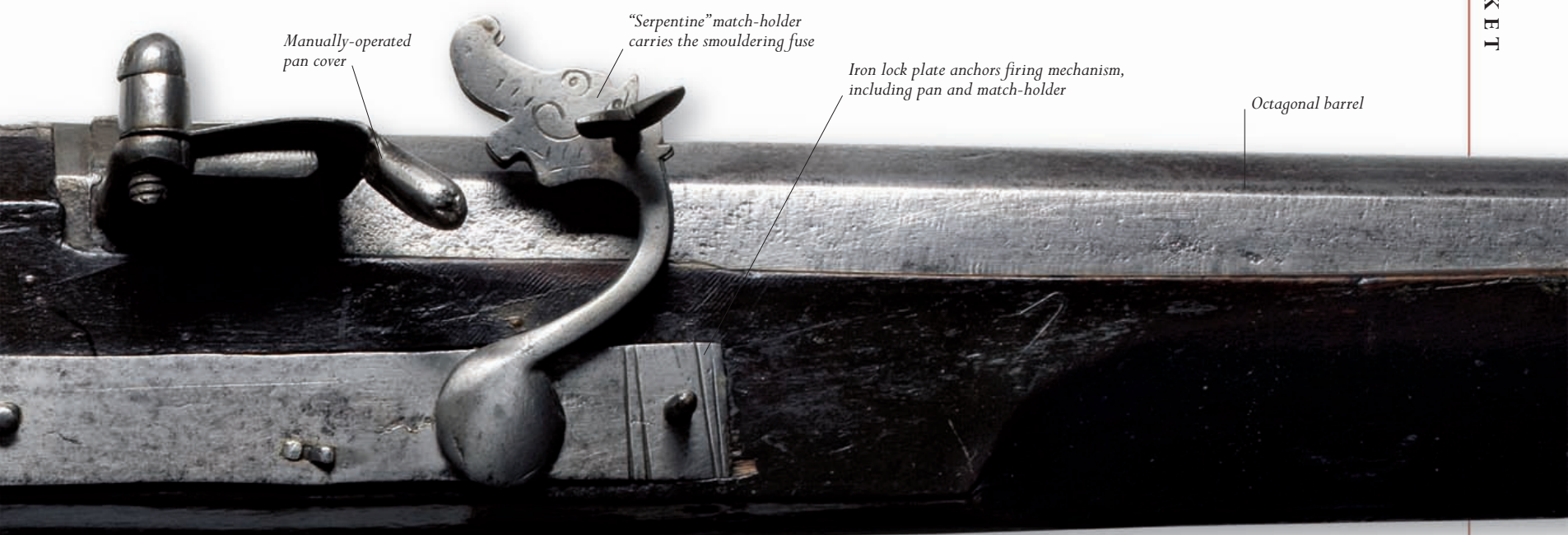


IN ACTION

MATCHLOCK DRILL

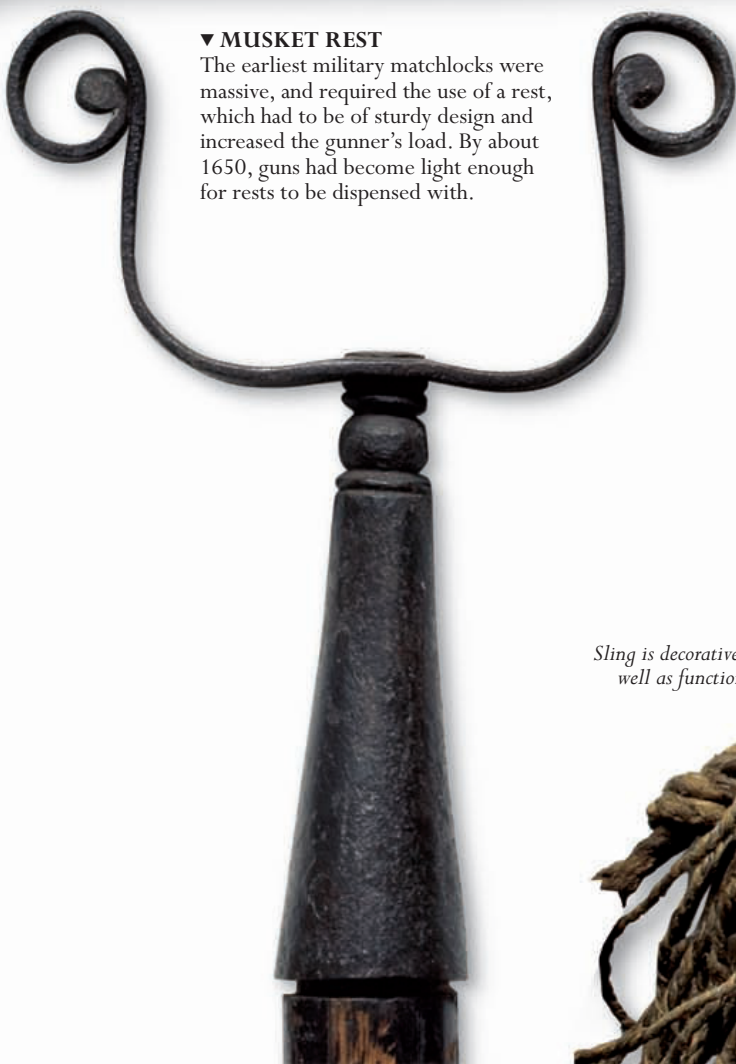
In the first of these pictures from a Dutch drill manual, the match in the musketeer's left hand is already lit. In the second, he pours gunpowder from a flask on his bandolier. He then rams down a musket ball, before preparing to pour priming powder into the pan from a priming flask, keeping the smouldering match at a safe distance in his left hand.

► Good dexterity was required to load matchlocks in the field.



▼ MUSKET REST

The earliest military matchlocks were massive, and required the use of a rest, which had to be of sturdy design and increased the gunner's load. By about 1650, guns had become light enough for rests to be dispensed with.



► POWDER FLASK

This example is made of wood covered with velvet and reinforced with iron. It is designed to hold fine-grained priming powder – the narrow spout makes it easier to pour into the pan.

▼ LEAD BALL

Matchlock muskets fired a ball made from lead that was cast slightly smaller in diameter than the bore of the gun. This was because residues from the burning powder quickly fouled the barrel, making loading difficult.

Sling is decorative as well as functional

